

Names in Steel

She ran her fingers down the empty shot glass, picking it up and staring into it, trying to catch a glimpse of her own eyes in the curved reflection.

This is where she met Roze-three years ago for the first time. Melly's.

She couldn't remember exactly how long it had been since Roze left. Maybe two months?
Her best guess.

Her favorite memory in the bar was Roze's 29th birthday. Even on Roze's special day, Fendra had passed out drunk and of course, Roze carried her back to their apartment.

Now, the bar felt estranged. The dim lights illuminated unfamiliar faces. The air was full of unfamiliar voices, drunk banter, bad pickup lines, a faint pulse of music, and memories she didn't want to hold on to.

She shot down her second tequila.
And left.

The walk home felt pointless. Every step a drag an act performed by the body, not the mind. She made it back to the apartment at the end of Arwel Street. The keychain. The "Welcome Home" doormat. Each one a painful souvenir from a life once lived, once laughed, now just memories, heavy burdens on already-weak shoulders.

It was quarter past eight when she got home. She collapsed on her bed.
Roze's scent still lingered faintly in the sheets each trace a sharper wound.
Fendra fell asleep drunk again that night.

She woke to the sound of an ambulance siren splitting the quiet.
2:30 AM.
The bed was still empty.

She looked into the dark room, hoping to see Roze standing beside her, waking her from this grief.
But it wasn't a nightmare.
This *was* life.
Life without Roze.

She opened the refrigerator, hoping maybe she'd brought leftovers from Melly's, but it was empty.
She poured a glass of water, sat at the kitchen table, opened her laptop.
She checked her emails nothing urgent, nothing that mattered.

Then something caught her eye in the sea of unread messages.

From: Merrox Chemicals.

A new name, she thought.

She opened the email.

Subject: Employment Offer – Chemical Logistics & Compliance Role (Merrox Chemicals)

From: hr@merroxchem.com

To: f.romwell89@gmail.com

Date: Wednesday, 2:14 AM

Dear Ms. Romwell,

We are pleased to offer you the position of Logistics & Compliance Coordinator at our Merrox Chemicals facility in [Town A].

The role involves oversight of regulated chemical transport, inventory logging, and ensuring material movement remains compliant with internal and state safety protocols. This is a full-time position with relocation support and competitive compensation.

If interested, kindly confirm your acceptance within 72 hours so we may begin the onboarding process.

Sincerely,

Helen R. Ways

HR Coordinator

Merrox Chemicals

hr@merroxchem.com

"W-wait... I... I-I d-don't r-remember wr-w-r-writing this..."

She opened her sent folder, trying to find any trace of an application or earlier correspondence.

Nothing.

Not a single message to or from Merrox.

"You did this?"

She asked herself in a voice that sounded too familiar.

Her eyes were heavy.
She closed the laptop. Didn't think twice.
Went to bed.

The next morning, she didn't think about the email, how or why she received it in the first place the only thing running through her mind was the dream she had.

In her dream, Fendra walked into a visibly empty street, a street with a sign bearing no name, looking at the sign it gave her a sense of longing, that she was always meant to stand here to come here, but after a few moments her sense of longing was completely replaced by content, a feeling she actually longed for all her life, shaking these emotions off, she entered the nameless street.

Stark contrast.

To her left, warmth pulsed from the houses.

Flickering brazen yellow lights glowed behind glass windows. Laughter poured from open doorways like perfume. Smoke from the chimneys curled upward in the shape of dancing figures, and faint piano music played not from any one house, but from all of them, rising and falling together like one synchronized breath.

The colors were rich: deep maroon bricks, lush greens, gold-painted mailboxes. One window even had stained glass reds and purples glinting like wine in sunlight.

It was impossible not to look. It felt like a future of bliss.

But the more she stared, the more she noticed the smiles didn't reach the eyes.

The dancing shadows twisted too tightly.

The laughter rang a little too perfectly like it was looping. Practiced.

Wrong. Fendra was certain no was in the houses, she was alone here

To her right, everything was still.

The houses were tall, colorless, made of stone and rusted steel. Their windows were crystal clear. The doors were wooden planks, each warped from rain and time, with no names, no numbers, not even doorbells.

No smoke. No sound. Just the occasional shudder as if the houses were breathing slowly in the cold.

A light frost lined the gutters. The sky above this side looked older somehow like it remembered something terrible.

Yet there was something honest about it.

No performance. No music. Just presence.

It didn't beg to be trusted-it dared you to.

She began walking down the middle of the road dividing the houses and then on her left she saw someone for the first time.

A man, sitting in his front porch in one of the houses, she stepped closer to her until the man looked at her asked, "23 years I have waited for you", his voice wasn't that of regret or contempt but rather his tone was full of temptation and allure, fendra was stunned by the voice, "will you make me wait longer, because I can".

Fendra stepped up to the man's porch, the railing on the steps leading to the man's porch were ash gray, the steps themselves were maroon and the wooden floor of the porch was a beautiful warm mahogany, "you like the colors don't you, but don't worry everyone who comes to visit me likes it, it makes them happy for some reason", he said with a sneer on his face.

"Have a seat", fendra sat opposite to him on the wooden lawn chairs, "quite comfortable aren't they?", the man let out a slight chuckle.

Fendra finally spoke to the man, "who a-ar-are you?, where am I?".

"Nowhere, this is everywhere, its just a question of where you are not? You see", the man said with a manner that seemed to be of a humorous intent.

"what should you be asking more importantly is why you are here?", the man said as he reached into the breast pocket of his coat and pointed to it with his eyes, "Im here to sell, and you are here to buy".

"bu-buy wha-what?", fendra asked the man.

"Perspective", the man answered in an instant with a grin on his face, "but you see it comes with a price", the smile on his face grew to a full smile.

"I-I don't have an-any-anything t-tt-to o-offer".

"sure you do, you aren't so stupid to come to buy something if you you didn't have anything to sell or to offer".

“wa-dd-you want”, fendra asked him with a worried look on her face.

The man opened the purple satin pouch that he took out of his pocket and said, “I want your choice”, then he leaned back on his chair and again pointed to the satin pouch with his eyes as it was now open set on the table in front of them.

The opened pouch revealed a beautiful gold bracelet with an unnaturally bright gold color twisted like vines with an intricate pattern of beautiful leaves, in the middle of the bracelet was set a blood red ruby, its shine was almost blinding but it was too beautiful to look away.

As fendra picked up the bracelet amazed by its beauty, the man’s voice cut her thoughts as he said, “I know...I know its only the most beautiful thing you’ve ever seen, but are you willing to the price for it?”.

“I still don’t u-und-understand w-what exactly y-y-you want from me.”, fendra replied.

“Well fortunately for us it doesn’t matter if you understand it or not, the question is are you willing to pay for it?”, the man replied in an unruly manner.

“I can’t buy t-this from y-you s-ssir, yo-you ne-need to u-understand.”, fendra set the bracelet down on the table and let out a sigh of frustration, she leaned back on her chair, running her fingers through her hair.

She looked out towards the street and saw someone else, another man sitting down across the street on one of the houses.

Without turning back to the man, she asked him, “who’s that?”

The man replied, “no one, he’s me, another vendor in this beautiful street”, the man said with a slight chuckle.

“w-well –what is he s-elling?”, fendra asked.

The man laughed first and then replied, “Perspective”, after he said that he burst into a huge laughter, fendra now looked at the laughing man with a look of surprise on her face and began laughing with him.

Their laughter rang across the porch like broken bells.

Fendra didn’t even know why she was laughing anymore it felt easy here. Too easy. The kind of laughter that doesn’t come from joy but from exhaustion. From surrender.

The vendor wiped an imaginary tear from his eye, settling back in his chair with a satisfied sigh.

But something pulled at the edge of her mind. A presence .Her laughter trailed off. Across the street, past the swirling warmth and golden windows, a figure sat on a crooked stone step.

No movement. No words. Just stillness.

The air around him looked colder. The colors duller. Even the sound seemed thinner where he sat like the world breathed differently on that side.

Fendra blinked.

The man on the porch followed her gaze. His smile never faded, but his tone sharpened just slightly. “Don’t bother. He never says what you want to hear.”

The first vendor didn’t stop her. He only tilted his head, watching with quiet amusement as she stepped off the porch.

Crossing the street felt strange like walking between dreams.

The warmth behind her thinned. Her feet met gravel instead of polished wood. The lights disappeared.

And then the silence grew.

With each step, the sweetness of the other side peeled away like an old coat. And in its place a bare wind, a stillness that wasn’t inviting, but true.

She reached the other side. And the second vendor looked up at her for the first time.

His eyes were gray and hollow, almost as if one could see past the man’s eyes, Fendra grew uncomfortable as she continued looking in the man’s eyes, until the silence between them was broken.

“Sit”.

Fendra sat down but on her knees, but the man repeated, “Sit”.

Despite the coarse gravel of the road fendra sat down, surrendering to the earth itself and crossed her legs, “What do y-you sell?” fendra asked the man.

“Perspective”, the man was blunt but not harsh there was a stillness in his voice, free from metaphors and strange connotations.

“And the p-rice to pp-pay is my choice”, fendra said calmly.

“Nothing more, nothing less your choice”, his voice clear and calm now.

The man then picked up something from the ground where he sat what seemed to be an old rag from a blacksmith’s shop, full of stains of old rust and burn marks. He put the rag as it on the wooden plank in between them and asked fendra, “open it”.

Fendra was not hesitant, she looked into the man’s gray eyes as she opened up the folded rag to reveal another bracelet...not of gold, silver or some other precious metal, it was forged iron. Dark, pitted, scratched. Twisted like it had once been straight, then warped under pressure. The clasp was uneven. It looked unfinished.

A faint, pulsing blue line ran through the metal like a vein glowing softly, but not invitingly. Like something buried under ice.

At its center was a stone. Not a ruby. Not a gem. Just a black shard. Sharp, jagged, and ugly.

It looked like something that had been through the trenches of war surviving fire and blood.

Fendra picked up the bracelet. It was heavy, cold to the touch she could feel its empty coldness in the bones of her palm, as she was looking at the bracelet the harsh coldness didn’t feel uncomfortable or unusual in her hands, it was a constant sense of soothing and relief.

Fendra gently placed the bracelet back on the wooden plank.

“Your choice, Fendra will you pay me the price for my perspective?” the man said in a neutral tone not cold, not enthusiastic, just saying the words for what they were.

“I cant d-decide...i-i-I mean I’m not sure”, she sounded unsure of herself, “thank you for your offer”. Fendra picked herself up and turned back to go to the man selling the gold bracelet again. As soon as she started walking she could see the man standing across the street smile again, with Fendra’s each step his smile grew even more, and as soon as she was about to arrive at the porch steps she woke up.

“So you’re telling me that 2 old creeps tried to sell you...*bracelets*...”

“Yes that’s ex-exactly what happened”

“Fen I keep telling you not to drink right before sleeping every night, I mean seriously it’s like you have no control over your fucking life ever since Roze left, get your shit together”

“i-I have been trying, t-trust me”

“You can’t call it “trying” when you keep going to Melly’s every evening after you get off work and then drink yourself to sleep every night”

“Josie...God i-I don’t k-know what t-to tell you”

“Just forget it I mean it’s no good trying to talk to you...anyways did you see the pictures that Alan sent us from his trip to Merrox’s grand-opening”

“Merrox?”, Fendra felt the name cut into her thoughts.

“Yeah...Merrox, you know one of the big shots from Miami, they opened a new logistics warehouse or something... I think like 50 miles from a small port in...”

“I-I don’t remember, sorry can I see those photos” fendra asked.

“Sure I mean Alan just sent these yesterday, but I showed you the pictures he sent from like a month ago? You don’t remember those?”

“Josie I-I’m sorry I can’t r-rem-remember anything right now”, her voice shook a bit now.

“Hey fen you sure you’re alright there?”

“Yeah I’m fine, it-it-its just that dream I had l-last night”

“Alright here see for yourself”, Josie handed fendra her phone.

It was a collection of photos from the warehouse, some officials and a few selfies from Alan that he found, as she was scrolling through the pictures, a video played. The video showed Alan talking to a cop about some break-in that was recently reported to the authorities but it just turned out to be a false alarm. As Fendra was looking at the videos her eyes fixated on something, she was practically staring at the screen now.

“You think that cop’s hot right?”, Josie said with a playful way.

Fendra looked at Josie with a disappointed look, “I was looking at –the br-bracelet h-he’s wearing”

“Fen seriously enough with the bracelet”, Josie sounded annoyed now. “Anyways I’ll see you after lunch alright, take care fen”.

“Take care Jo,bye”.

The rest of the day at work went down like everyday, fendra got off at 5 and instead of making her habitual stop at Melly’s, today she headed home straight from work. As soon as she got home, she threw her bag and the laptop on the table dragged a chair for herself and

opened the pictures again that she asked Jo to send her, she began skimming through the all the photos trying to find the video with the cop again and she did. It was Alan and the cop in the video, Alan was asking the cop why he was here to which he replied that he was here about a security breach at one of the warehouses but it turned out to be a false alarm.

She paused the video at just the right frame and took a screenshot so she could have a closer look, at the bracelet the cop was wearing.

She trying zooming into the screenshot to get a closer look, and at first look it just looked like a regular bracelet made of steel or some other cheap metal it had a slight shine.

But the more fendra kept looking at the bracelet, her unease and a sense of displeasure grew within her, not because of the dream last night but it was something else, it felt close for some reason, something much more personal. To fendra it felt like opening an old box from your garage and then finding exactly the thing you were looking for. Fendra didn't like the feeling she closed the picture and called Jo asking her how old was this exact video, Jo told her it Alan sent the video with the cop more than a month ago when he went to Merrox's grand-opening as a representative of "Purifix Solutions".

A month ago. . .

Her concerns were growing by the moment, what is Merrox and why did she get a job offer from them but more importantly how? How did Merrox find her and why was this happening. She opened her emails on her laptop again, "72 hours", she had till tomorrow to decide to either accept or decline their offer.

"wh-y did y-y-you do this?"

She searched through her spam, inbox, outbox emails everything, yet all in vain, she couldn't find a single message linking her and Merrox. She stared at the screen for an hour, her hair pulled back and stuck between her fingers.

She decided it was time for a shot now. She took her bottle of tequila and downed two shots, and now she had the confidence and the courage to write back to Merrox.

She accepted the job offer from Merrox.

The corporate offices of Purifix smelled of synthetic lavender and ozone a clinical, sterile scent that did nothing to mask the suffocating weight of the past two months. Fendra stared at the cardboard box on her desk, containing nothing but a ceramic mug with a chipped handle, a handful of cheap pens, and a bottle of prescription pills she hadn't touched in weeks. Her transition to Merrox Chemicals in Port Erybus had been finalized with alarming speed. The administrative loop had closed seamlessly; an automated email had simply informed her that

her transfer request one she had no conscious memory of typing out was approved. She assumed it was a late-night, tequila-fueled whim. A desperate bid to outrun Roze's ghost.

As she taped the box shut, Jo lingered by, holding a yellow plastic duck she'd taken from the safety compliance display near the water cooler.

"Did you know," Jo said, squeezing the toy so it gave a pathetic, wheezing squeak, "that these things don't actually float straight if the weight distribution in the mold is off? They just sort of like I don't know the word umm...capsize, yeah they just lean to one side. Face down in the bath."

Fendra stopped taping, her fingers tightening around the plastic dispenser. "I... I didn't know that, Jo."

"Yeah. It's a manufacturing flaw. You'd think a company dedicated to flotation toys would have fixed this fucking flaw by now, but no they haven't figured it out yet." Jo turned the duck over, staring intensely at its flat underbelly. "Anyway. Port Erybus. Lots of water up there. Don't go buying any cheap ducks. They'll just drown."

"I w-won't," Fendra mumbled, staring at the floorboards between them as if looking for an escape hatch. "No d-ducks f-fo-for me."

"Good. Good call." Jo cleared her throat, the sound loud against the hum of the office HVAC. She tossed the duck lightly into her open cardboard box, right next to her chipped mug. "Well. Keep your head down, Romwell."

She turned to leave, but the sheer weight of the empty office, the clinical lighting, and the sudden realization that she was leaving everything she knew hit Fendra like a physical blow. She didn't just want to be a ghost escaping in the night.

"J-Jo," she blurted out.

Jo paused, turning back. Before her awkward workplace radar could go off, Fendra stepped across the threshold of her cubicle and wrapped her arms tightly around Jo's torso.

Jo stiffened instantly, her arms hovering in the air but Fendra didn't let go. She buried her face against Jo's shoulder, holding onto her with a desperate, crushing intensity a silent plea for someone, anyone, to acknowledge that she was still alive, that she was breaking, that she was terrified.

Slowly, the tension left Jo's shoulders. She let out a quiet, heavy sigh and wrapped her arms around Fendra's back, hugging her back with a fierce, unexpected warmth. They stood there in the quiet hum of the accounting department, holding onto each other in a deep, wordless embrace that said everything their pointless conversation couldn't. It was real, it was raw, and it was the only genuine piece of comfort she would take with her.

An hour later, Fendra was in her rusted sedan, watching the pristine, white-paneled headquarters of Purifix shrink in her rearview mirror. Ahead lay the grey, salt-crusting skyline of Port Erybus, where the Merrox chemical plant loomed like a monolith of rusted iron and secrets, waiting to welcome her.

The first week at new place was going much better than she had anticipated

On her first weekend at Merrox, the staff that had come from other cities and states were granted a free tour of the town, "Port Erybus".

After 2 weeks Fendra had finally settled into her new home, all her furniture was brought here and the rest of the belongings the moving company managed in ten days. On a Saturday evening, fendra went out with Reggie. Reggie lived 2 apartments next to Fendra and helped her move and agreed to take her down to his favorite bar "The Honey Well".

"So what brings you to Erybus?"

"Wo-rk, what about you?"

"Oh no-no-no I have been here 6 years now, I moved into an apartment with my cousin and about 6 months ago I moved into the building we live in now...so yeah"

"s-so what do you d-do for work?"

"you know it's whatever I do a lot of things, I mean...yeah this isn't working out really well, I got laid off like 5 months from my job and I think I'm gonna have to move back in with my cousin cuz I cant really afford rent here anymore"

Fendra gave a friendly but nervous laughter as she sipped her drink, "I'm not pa-aying for t-these drinks."

Reggie looked confused and then nervous as he couldn't figure out whether she was serious or not, until fendra finally laughed, "R-r-relax", Reggie laughed too now.

Reggie left to go to his cousin's and Fendra ordered an uber.

"Here for Fendra Rom-Romwell?"

"y-yes that's me". Fendra got in the car.

"you know its my first time seeing you here, you new here? I pick up a lot of people from the Honeywell.

“yes...I moved h-ere t-two wweeks ago”

“oh that’s great I mean why did you move here, work maybe or something else?”

Fendra nodded her head, yes.

As the woman driving was about to say something fendra pulled out a card from her purse and gave it to her to read. The card read:

“Hello my name is Fendra Romwell, I have a severe speech impediment and I stutter a lot during speaking. Please do not mind if I nod my head to answer your questions, Im not being rude. Thank you ;).”

“oh im sorry to hear that fendra, hey my name is Cassandra but everyone calls me cici so you can call me cici for the rest of the ride”

Fendra nodded her head yes with a smile.

The ride was going smooth until cici caught fendra looking at her in the front mirror

“you like what you see huh?”, cici laughingly said. Fendra was too embarrassed to even look straight so she started looking out the car window.

“and that is Erybus’ police station that we are now just passing”

Fendra still didn’t move away from the window.

“do you mind if I put on some musi...”, the sound of the thunder cut her off.

Fendra screamed, but now she was even more embarrassed as she just covered her face with her hands.

Cici tried to control her laughter but a light chuckle still managed to slip through her lips, thankfully fendra was still too scared to notice cici’s chuckle.

Fendra noticed the first raindrop just a little to the right edge of her window, a few seconds later 2 more fell on the top of the window

By the time they reached fendra’s apartment the few rain drops had turned into a heavy rain.

“alright here we are, don’t forget to give me a fair rating I’m still new on this whole Uber thing”

“t-thank you I w-wi-ll”, as fendra opened the door to leave she stopped halfway and got back in the car, she tried to say something but typing it out her phone seemed more convenient right now, she typed her message and gave her phone to Cici.

“oh no-no its alright, it really is I don’t wanna disturb the rest of your right by staying plus we don’t even know how long this rain is gonna go, but thank you very much, you’re too kind”

Cici watched as fendra’s whole body reacted to her answer, fendra’s shoulders lowered slowly and the light in her eyes faded away in an instant, Cici saw as fendra lowered her head and went to grab her purse again and got ready to step out again.

“hey I have an idea”, Cici typed something into fendra’s phone as fendra looked at her with a look in her eyes that resembled hope.

“alright here is my number Fendra, and anytime you want to...you know get to know the town better or maybe...like anything else, you know just give me a call”

Fendra quickly grabbed the phone from cici’s hands, she wanted to get out of the car as soon as possible now if she didn’t want to embarrass herself even more.

“I wi-will”, fendra said while running to her apartment.

“I know you *will*”, cici replied to herself with a chuckle.

Fendra stood outside her small rented room, shivering in a coat that wasn't thick enough for the coast. Her fingers were raw. She was late for her shift at Merrox. The rusted sedan had finally died the night before, the engine giving up with a wet, metallic rattle.

A yellow cab pulled up to the curb, its brakes squealing against the damp air. The passenger door swung open.

"Get in before you turn into an icicle, Romwell," Cassandra said from the driver's seat. Cici. She had a crooked smile and a thermal mug of coffee sitting in the console.

Fendra scrambled inside, the heater blasting her face with dry, dusty warmth. "I-I didn’t c-call a cab, Cici. I c-can't af-afford"

"Shut up and drink," Cici interrupted, shoving the mug into Fendra’s hands. "I was in the neighborhood. Besides, you look pathetic out there."

Fendra took a sip. Black, bitter, perfect. She looked over at Cici the sharp jawline, the dark hair tucked behind her ears, the faint smell of tobacco and cheap vanilla air freshener. "T-Thank you."

"Don't mention it. Seriously. She glanced at Fendra, her eyes softening. "You got plans after your shift? Or are you just gonna go home and stare at the wall again?"

Fendra’s face flushed. "I... I might r-read. Or w-work on the inventory sheets."

"Boring," Cici laughed, stopping the cab outside the rusted iron gates of Merrox. The plant loomed over the docks like a gray monster. "How about a real plan? There's a diner by the pier. Best greasy burgers in town. Let me take you out tomorrow. A real date. No meter running."

Fendra's heart did a strange, clumsy flutter. It had been so long since anyone looked at her like that. Since Roze. But Cici's eyes didn't look like a memory; they looked real.

"I-I'd... I'd l-like that," Fendra whispered.

"Good. It's a date." Cici winked. "Now get to work before the foreman docks you."

The date had been perfect. And the second one. And the third.

By the second month, Cici was the only reason Fendra didn't buy a bottle of tequila every night. But the dark didn't just go away. It waited.

It happened on a Tuesday. Fendra had fallen asleep on Cici's couch after they spent hours talking about nothing just sitting close, their shoulders touching under a heavy wool blanket. No touching, just the quiet comfort of breathing the same air.

Cici woke up at 3:00 AM to get a glass of water.

The living room was pitch black, save for the pale light of a streetlamp slicing through the window. Fendra wasn't on the couch.

She was standing by the window. Her posture was entirely different not the usual slouch, not the timid, defensive curve of her shoulders. She stood perfectly straight, hands folded behind her back, staring down at the street where a police cruiser was slowly patrolling.

"Fen?" Cici whispered, holding the water glass. "Hey. Sleepwalking again?"

The woman by the window turned. Slowly. Her head tilted at an angle that felt completely wrong. When her eyes caught the light, they were wide, unblinking, and entirely hollow.

"You should be asleep, Cassandra," she said.

The voice was low. Smooth. It didn't hitch. It didn't trip over the consonants. There was no stutter. It was a cold, clinical command that made the hair on Cici's arms stand up.

Cici blinked, taking a step back. "Fen? Your... your voice."

The woman turned back to the window, ignoring her completely. "Go back to bed or you'll catch a cold, the air is turning."

Cici stood frozen in the hallway for five minutes, the cold water glass sweating in her hand. When she finally crept back to the living room, Fendra was back on the couch, curled into a small, shivering ball, snoring softly.

The next morning, Fendra burned the toast because she was stuttering so hard trying to apologize for dropping a spoon. Cici didn't mention the window. She just watched her, a knot tightening in her stomach.

They didn't rush into anything physical, and that was what Fendra loved most. Cici understood the bruising left behind by a bad ending. They spent their weekends walking along the grey, salt-crusted docks, hands buried deep in their pockets, occasionally brushing against each other.

"My dad used to say this town absorbs people," Cici said one afternoon, throwing a pebble into the dark, churning water of the harbor. "Like, you come here to get lost, and the fog just eats you".

Fendra looked at the rusted hull of an old cargo ship. "I... I th-think I was already a sh-shadow when I g-got here."

Cici stopped walking. She reached out, her fingers hesitant, and gently touched Fendra's cheek. Her hand was warm, smelling of salt. She didn't kiss her. She just held her face there, forcing Fendra to look up, to stay present.

"You're not a shadow to me, Fen," Cici said softly. "You're the brightest thing in this dump."

Fendra closed her eyes, leaning into the warmth of that hand. For a second, the heavy, dark weight in the back of her mind the part that always felt like it was scratching to get out went completely silent.

Fendra started losing time.

It was happening more often now. She would wake up at her desk at Merrox, or in the middle of her kitchen, with hours missing. Her head always ached with a blinding, white-hot pressure right behind her eyes.

Cici came over to Fendra's room early on a Saturday to surprise her with breakfast. The front door was unlocked.

"Fen?" Cici called out, stepping into the dim apartment.

No answer.

Cici walked into the bedroom. Fendra was sitting at the small wooden desk in the corner. The overhead light was off, the only illumination coming from a single desk lamp angled sharply downward.

Fendra was writing. Or rather, she was drawing.

Cici approached quietly, not wanting to startle her. She looked over Fendra's shoulder and felt a sudden, inexplicable chill.

The entire notepad was covered in the same drawing. Over and over again. Hundreds of them, scratched into the paper so hard the ink had bled through three pages down. It was a crude, geometric sketch of a heavy, industrial steel bracelet. The lines were sharp, violent, and precise.

"Fen?" Cici whispered, reaching out to touch her shoulder.

Fendra didn't jump. She didn't flinch. She slowly laid the pen down on the desk. When she looked up at Cici, her expression was completely blank.

"It's a manufacturing flaw," Fendra said.

The voice was that smooth, unhitched cadence again. No stutter. Cold as iron.

"What is?" Cici asked, her heart hammering against her ribs.

"The balance," she replied, staring at the drawing of the bracelet. "A calculation error from twenty-three years ago. It's finally being corrected."

Cici backed away, her breath catching. "Fen, you're scaring me. Stop talking like that."

Fendra closed her eyes. She rubbed her temples, her shoulders suddenly slumping forward into their usual, hesitant curve. When she opened her eyes again, she blinked rapidly, looking around the room in confusion.

"C-Cici?" Fendra stammered, her voice small and trembling. "Wh... when did you g-get here? My head... it r-really hurts."

Cici looked from the trembling Fendra to the torn notebook pages. She swallowed the lump in her throat and forced a smile. "Just got here, sweetie. Come on. Let's get some air."

They took the apartment on the end of Arwel Street.

It was a small, under-insulated place with creaking floorboards and a view of the gray shipyard, but it was theirs. Fendra carried her single cardboard box inside the one with the chipped mug and the yellow rubber duck Jo had given her.

"Home sweet home," Cici said, dumping her duffel bag on the floor and wrapping her arms around Fendra's waist from behind, resting her chin on Fendra's shoulder.

Fendra smiled, leaning back against her. "It's... it's p-perfect, Cici."

"We're gonna be fine here, Fen. No more ghosts."

That night, they slept in the same bed for the first time. They just held each other, Fendra's head resting against Cici's chest, listening to the steady, calm rhythm of her heartbeat. Fendra felt a profound, aching sense of peace. She was safe. She was loved.

But late in the night, while Cici slept, the body rose.

It didn't make a sound. It walked out into the empty living room, staring down at the bare wooden floorboards directly beneath the ceiling fan.

The eyes looked down, calculating the distance. Measuring the space. The hands reached into the pocket of the heavy coat hanging by the door, pulling out four thick, heavy iron nails. The fingers ran over the sharp points, completely steady, completely unbothered by the cold.

"Perfect."

The rain in Port Erybus didn't wash things clean; it just made the rust bleed.

Chief Sullivan was already at the scene when Detective Orus C. Woods arrived.

"I called for you an hour ago. One fucking hour it took you to get here. Are you even listening to me, Woods?"

Woods couldn't hear a single goddamn word. The noise of the three uniform officers rushing in and out of the apartment was just static. His eyes were glued to the center of the room. To her.

Cassandra. Hanging from the ceiling fan.

A violent, shaking tremor started in his chest. His jaw locked so hard his teeth ached. Nobody in this miserable, underfunded department knew. Nobody knew about the nights he'd waited by her cab. The sharp, quiet way she'd rejected him because she couldn't love a man. They didn't know he loved her anyway. He knew her. Cici wasn't weak. She wouldn't fucking quit.

"Woods? WOODS? Goddamn it, son, what the hell is wrong with you?" the Chief roared, shoving his face into Woods' line of sight. "We've been waiting for you for an hour. It's time for cleanup. We're almost done here."

"Done?" Woods let out a low, hollow laugh. It sounded like glass breaking.

“Did I make a joke, Woods? Maybe you ain't heard me clear. We're done here. It's a suicide case. Poor girl finally cracked.”

“No.”

“What do you mean, *No*? Look at her. She hung herself, Woods.”

“You're wrong, Chief.”

Woods suddenly lunged into the room. His hands shook as he pulled up his camera, clicking the shutter furiously. He didn't look at the small sitting stool placed a few feet away. He looked at the floorboards directly beneath her bare feet.

Four iron nails. Sunk deep into the wood. A perfect two-by-three-foot rectangle. Empty.

He zoomed the lens onto the soles of Cici's feet. The skin was dark, blistered, ruined. It looked like extreme frostbite. It looked like rot. He snapped the pictures like a maniac, desperate to catch every detail before Sullivan's clean-up crew washed the truth down the drain.

A day later, Woods slammed through the front doors of the station. He was completely drenched, water pooling at his boots, his chest heaving like a cornered animal.

He screamed into the bullpen. “Where is he? How could he do this?”

“I'm right here, Woods.”

Woods spun around. Chief Sullivan was standing by the desk, holding Cassandra's case file. “It's over, son. The case is closed.”

“NO IT'S FUCKING NOT! She didn't kill hers—”

“Yes she fucking did, WOODS! And you're too stupid to accept that the woman you once loved isn't here anymore.”

The word *loved* hit Woods like a brick to the teeth. “You're wrong. YOU'RE FUCKING WRONG AND I'M GONNA PROVE IT TO YOU!”

“You're not doing shit, Woods. This case is closed. We won't waste any more time on this. We have a new case to solve, Woods. The sooner you get your hands on it, the better.” Sullivan sneered, tossing the folder onto a desk. “We already interviewed Cassandra's girlfriend. Fendra. She's clear. She wasn't even here the night Cassandra died. She's clear, we're all clear. The case is CLOSED, you hear me, Woods? Closed.”

The Chief turned his back, walking toward his office.

The bullpen went dead silent. Woods didn't think. The rage broke through his skull. He ran.

He grabbed Sullivan by the back of his neck, yanked him around, and smashed his fist straight into the Chief's mouth.

The crunch of splitting skin exploded in the room. Sullivan staggered back against a desk, spitting blood.

“YOU FUCKING PIECE OF SHIT! HOW CAN YOU SAY THAT MY CASSIE KILLED HERSELF?” Woods screamed, his voice cracking, raw with pure grief. He lunged again, driving another heavy punch straight into Sullivan's nose.

“Get him off! Lock him down!” The officers finally snapped out of it. Three deputies threw their weight onto Woods, grabbing his jacket, dragging him backward. Woods thrashed like a wild animal, his eyes bloodshot, kicking at the desks. “I’LL FUCKING KILL YOU, SULLY! I’LL FUCKING KILL YOU!”

Sullivan wiped a thick smear of red from his broken mouth. His eyes went venomous.

“Kill me? You pathetic piece of shit,” Sullivan hissed, stepping right into Woods' face. “You just can't accept the fact that dyke whore of yours that you FUCKING LOVED didn't love you back! Admit it, Woods! Admit it, you can't accept it! You loved her, and you're blinded by love, son!”

Something inside Woods snapped completely. The last thread of the disciplined detective tore.

With a guttural roar, he ripped his arm free from the officers holding him. He put his entire weight into a final, vicious hook that caught Chief Sullivan squarely on the jaw.

The impact sounded like a splitting log. Sullivan's eyes rolled back. His knees buckled instantly, and he went down hard, knocked out cold against the linoleum floor.

Nobody moved. Nobody breathed. Woods stood over the unconscious Chief, his knuckles dripping blood onto the case file. He looked at the stunned bullpen, turned, and bolted out the double doors, disappearing straight into the blinding Port Erybus rain.

The rain hadn't stopped for thirty days. It just changed directions, sweeping sideways off the gray harbor, hammering against the cracked window of the abandoned motel room Woods had been squatting in.

He was drowning in his own breaths, counting each, each measuring more painful than the last.

The room was a labyrinth of obsession. The walls were covered in the photos he'd taken before Sullivan chucked him out. Printouts of Cassandra's face, staring blankly at the ceiling fan. Close-ups of the four iron nails. Close-ups of her feet the horrific, blackened, blistered skin on her soles that the department called *post-mortem pooling*.

"It's not pooling," Woods muttered, his voice a cracked, ragged rasp. He hadn't slept more than twenty hours across the entire month. His eyes were deeply bloodshot, surrounded by dark, bruised rings. His charcoal overcoat was stained, smelling of cheap whiskey, sweat, and stale tobacco. "It's not pooling. It's necrosis. It's cell death. How?"

He glared at the photo of the four nails. A perfect two-by-three-foot rectangle.

"What went inside the rectangle?" he screamed at the empty room. He grabbed a half-empty bottle of whiskey and hurled it at the wall. It shattered, glass and amber liquid raining down over Cassandra's face.

He lost it. The pressure behind his eyes exploded.

Woods crashed out. He kicked the wooden desk, splintering the legs, sending his notes, maps, and timelines scattering across the wet floorboards. He tore the photos off the walls with his bare hands, ripping them to shreds, screaming until his throat bled. He was a top-grad mastermind, the perfectionist, the guy who always found the missing variable and he was being outsmarted by a ghost. A ghost that smelled like wood polish.

"WHO WERE YOU STARTING FOR?" he roared, slamming his bloodied knuckles into the drywall, leaving deep, red indents. "WHO was on the floor, Cassie? Tell me!"

He collapsed onto his knees amidst the debris, his chest heaving violently, gasping for air in the damp, freezing dark. His hands shook uncontrollably. He was broken. The town had absorbed him. He was just another gray shadow losing his mind.

Then, a sudden, high-pitched chirp cut through the sound of the storm.

His personal burner phone the number he'd given to absolutely nobody was vibrating on the mattress.

Woods froze. The blood dripped from his knuckles onto the shattered glass below.

He crawled over, his breathing shallow, and snatched the phone. He pressed it to his ear, his jaw clenched tight enough to break. He didn't say a word. He just listened, his heart hammering against his ribs.

A voice came through the static. It was smooth. Perfectly calm. It didn't hitch, it didn't trip over its words, and it completely lacked a stutter. Cold as iron.

"from twenty-three years ago detective. Stop breaking your hands against the wall. If you want the truth... let's talk about the bracelet."

The line went dead.

Woods didn't even have time to lower the burner phone from his ear before the lock on his door clicked. The wood groaned, swinging open into the freezing, dark motel room.

A woman stood in the threshold. Her posture was straight, her hands buried inside the deep pockets of a heavy wool coat. It was Cassandra's girlfriend. The stuttering chemist from Merrox. But the woman standing under the flickering hallway bulb didn't slouch, and she didn't look afraid. Her eyes were sharp, unblinking pieces of glass.

"Why are you so surprised, Detective?" she asked, her voice smooth, low, and completely unhitched. "At least make it a pleasant one by wiping away that awful look off your face. I can smell your morning breath from here... Should I invite myself in, or will you have some manners?"

Woods staggered backward, his boots catching on a torn piece of one of his crime scene photos. His mind scrambled, his analytical brain short-circuiting at the sound of the cadence. "H-h-how... wha..."

"I don't remember you having a speech impairment, Detective," she said, stepping inside and closing the door behind her with a soft, deliberate click. "You might have some underlying issues... better get them checked out."

"Who are you?" Woods rasped, his hand dropping toward the holster at his waist, his bloodshot eyes darting across her face. "Wh-why are you here?"

"Detective, I think you could be asking better questions. You know, be better at your job," she mocked, walking past him into the center of the living room without an ounce of hesitation. "You shouldn't be asking me who I am or how I got here. Now is not the time."

The woman walked into the room, taking a slow, clinical look around the wreckage. She looked at the smashed whiskey bottles, the walls stripped bare, the hundreds of shredded photos of Cassandra lying like snow on the floorboards.

"Quite impressive, I must say," she murmured, her fingers tracing the edge of the broken desk. "How close you've gotten to her. To me. To everything. But you know what's frustrating, Detective? You'll die knowing that it wasn't enough, what you did. This month, and the years before you've spent..."

"I asked you a question," Woods snarled. The last thread of his sanity snapped. He pulled his revolver out, the heavy steel barrel shaking violently as he leveled it straight at her chest.

The woman didn't flinch. She didn't even look at the gun. She just turned her head, offering him a thin, hollow smile.

"I am at the liberty of having a choice to answer you, isn't that right? I am not under arrest. So no, I'm not going to be answering any of your questions... for now."

"I ASKED YOU. A FUCKING QUESTION!" Woods roared.

BANG.

The gunshot exploded in the cramped, concrete room, deafeningly loud. The bullet tore straight through the drywall an inch from her left ear, spraying white plaster dust into her dark hair.

She didn't blink slowly turning her face back toward him, her expression as still as stone, completely unbothered by the sudden smell of gunpowder.

"Unfortunately, your enthusiasm will not get you any closer to the truth," she whispered, her voice dropping into a chilling calm that filled the room. "You don't scare me, Detective. You won't kill me. You *cannot* kill me. So let me bring you closer to the reality of your situation."

Woods' chest heaved violently, his vision blurring as he gripped the smoking revolver with both hands. He was looking at Fendra's face, but he was staring at a monster.

"The truth?" Woods choked out, his throat burning. "What truth? What the fuck are you even talking about? Wh-who are you... I think you should let me ask the questions for now."

She stepped forward, moving straight toward the barrel of the gun.

She didn't flinch. She just kept moving forward, slowly, until the cold, smoking steel of the barrel was pressed flat against her forehead. Her forehead. Fendra's forehead.

"Where is the bracelet?" she demanded. Her voice didn't shake. It was a flat, heavy command.

Woods blinked, his chest heaving, his fingers straining against the trigger. He was looking at a woman who should be running, but she was leaning into the iron. "What? What bracelet?"

"Where is *your* bracelet, Detective? There is only one answer. The sooner you provide it, the sooner you reach the truth and, ultimately, your death."

"My death?" Woods let out a ragged, desperate breath. He could feel the heat radiating from her skin. "You think you're leaving here? You think you're walking out after what you did to Cassie?"

Synthia let out a sharp, hollow laugh. It was a ugly, dry sound that cut through the smell of gunpowder. "Killed? Who? It's dangerous to jump to conclusions based on assumptions, Detective. Bad practice for a man in your line of work." She pressed her forehead harder against the gun, forcing his arm back a fraction of an inch. "You won't kill me. You can't."

"Try me."

"I'm past that phase," she whispered, her eyes narrowing into cold slits. "Why do you think I'm here? I'm here to hand you the truth you've been bleeding for these past two months. But I don't do charity, Woods. I want the steel."

She suddenly stepped back, the sudden lack of resistance almost making Woods stumble forward. She reached into her coat pocket, her movements smooth, deliberate, and entirely free of panic. She didn't pull out a weapon. She pulled out a small, crumpled piece of paper and tossed it onto the wreckage of the wooden desk.

"The old shipyard. Sector 4. The abandoned iron foundry," She said, her voice dropping into a clinical, business-like tone. "Tonight. Midnight."

Woods kept the revolver leveled at her head. "I'm not playing your goddamn games. You're coming with me to the precinct."

"The precinct?" She sneered, her lips curling into a mocking smile. "With what badge, Woods? You're a rogue agent squatting in a rotting motel room. You have nothing. No support, no forensics, and no time."

She walked toward the open door, turning back just before she stepped out into the dark, rain-slicked hallway.

"Come alone," she commanded, her eyes locking onto his with a terrifying, absolute dominance. "And come bare. No wire, no backup, no cops. Just you and that bracelet on your wrist. If I see a single shadow behind you, the truth burns, and you'll spend the rest of your pathetic life wondering how Cassandra slowly choked to death on that ceiling fan."

She offered him one final, stone-cold look. "Don't be late, Detective."

Before Woods could even find his voice, she stepped backward into the hallway and disappeared into the shadows, the sound of her heavy footsteps fading instantly into the steady, relentless roar of the Port Erybus rain.

The old iron foundry in Sector 4 smelled like decades of dead rust and frozen grease.

Woods stood in the center of the kill floor. He was bare. No coat, no wire, no badge. His shirt was soaked through, clinging to his skin. His hands were empty, hanging loosely at his sides.

The only thing of value he carried was the heavy, unpolished steel bracelet resting against his left wrist, catching the faint, greasy light filtering through the cracked skylights.

She walked forward with that same straight, terrifyingly calm posture. No coat this time. Just a dark shirt, her hands loose, her unblinking eyes fixed entirely on his wrist.

She stopped ten feet away. She tilted her head, her lips curling into a dry, humorless smile.

"Hello, detective, you must be dying to know who I am," she said, her voice dripping with clinical amusement. "I'm Synthia."

Woods' breath caught in his throat, his eyes darting across her face Fendra's face. "What the hell are you talking about?"

"Fendra doesn't have the stomach for the math, so I handle the ledger," Synthia stepped closer, her eyes turning into black flints. "Poor, fragile, stuttering Fendra. She's asleep, Detective. She doesn't even know we're having this conversation. She thinks she's dreaming of her dead girlfriend."

"You're... you're her," Woods rasped, his hand shaking.

"I am the part of her that didn't break when the world came crashing down. I was born twenty-three years ago in Fendra's mind, Detective, right here in the dirt of Port Erybus. Our mother was abused, discarded, and left pregnant in the slums of this pathetic town. When Fendra's father found out about the assault, he couldn't bear the shame. He took little Fendra and fled, leaving his pregnant wife behind to rot. But the trauma didn't just stay with the mother. It fractured the little girl he took with him."

Synthia tapped her own temple with a pale finger.

"Fendra couldn't carry the weight of what happened here. Her mind shattered, split right down the middle to protect itself. She got the fear, the guilt, and that pathetic stutter. I got the memory. I got the logic. I am the choice she is too weak to make. Twenty-three years I've been waiting in the dark of her mind, planning our return, while she remained mostly oblivious to my existence, yet she never denied it, she knew who I was, what I did for her for the last 23 years. Now every single move for the past six months her transfer to Merrox, her coming back to this town was me pulling the strings while she slept."

Woods staggered back a step, his chest heaving. "What does that have to do with me? And Cassandra? Cassie had nothing to do with any of this! Why did you kill her?!"

"Cassandra was an anomaly," she said clinically. "A variable I didn't account for. She started looking too closely at the gaps in Fendra's memory. She saw me, Woods. She caught me drawing that very bracelet in the dark. She was going to ruin the calculation. So, she had to be removed."

"How?" Woods screamed, tears finally cutting through the grime on his face. "How did you do it in a locked room?!"

"Simple states of matter, Detective. A two-by-three-foot block of industrial ice, pinned to the floorboards with four heavy iron nails so it wouldn't slide under her weight. I put the noose around her neck and left her standing bare on the ice. Over several hours, it melted. She slowly choked to death as her feet slipped away. And the smell? Waterproof lacquer, flooded over the wood to mask the water damage from your incompetent department."

Synthia took another step forward, pulling a heavy, black silenced pistol from behind her back. She leveled it perfectly at his forehead.

"She stood there for hours, Woods. Freezing. Her feet rotting from the frostbite before the rope finally took her. She died because of *you*. Because you couldn't stop looking for a ghost."

The words struck Woods with the force of a physical blow. The final thread of his spirit snapped. The analytical mind, the perfectionism, the rogue detective everything disintegrated into a vast, empty void of grief. Cassandra hadn't broken. She had been tortured and murdered because of his pathetic presence in this town.

He didn't raise his hands. He didn't look for a weapon. He just stared at Fendra's face, his eyes completely dead, his shoulders slumping into total defeat.

"I give up," Woods whispered. The rain seemed to go quiet in his ears. He looked at the barrel of the gun. "Just do it. It doesn't matter anym-."

"I know," Cynthia murmured, her voice dripping with a terrifying, quiet amusement. "But you see, Detective... I will not be the one to end this. *She* will."

Synthia took a step back, her cold commanding sneer still on her face, and then it all shifted, the sneer vanished, the sharpened eyes became timid and weak, the cold and tight composure loosened to a slight slouch and her shoulders curled.

Fendra blinked, the freezing Port Erybus rain smacking against her face, blurring her vision. Her right hand was shaking so violently the heavy black pistol wavered in the air.

"W-W-Woods?" Fendra's voice broke, her severe, agonizing stutter violently ripping back into her vocal cords and locking her jaw. She looked down at the weapon, then up at the man kneeling before her. "D-D-Detective? W-what... what am I d-doing?"

Kill him, Cynthia's voice hissed, echoing with an absolute, dominant clarity inside the walls of Fendra's skull. *Spill the blood of what defiled our mother. Spill it now, Fendra.*

“s-stop, shu-t up”. Fendra tried to shout.

“wh-what wh if yo-ure w-wr-wrong?”. Fendra said.

“Does it matter if we're right about what he is? Or does it only matter that we need to believe we're right? That we need him to be the monster so that we can stop being afraid?”, Synthia whispered again.

The air left Fendra's lungs. Her mind fractured under the pressure, the boundaries between her and the voice bleeding into pure horror. Hyperventilation tore at her throat. Tears flooded down her cheeks, mixing with the cold rain.

“I-I sorry wo-woods, I'm so-sorry”, fendra began crying, “I'm s-sorry woo-ds, but sh-she's ri-right”.

“You don't have to do this, Fendra, she wants it, not you, if you kill me, our Cici would have died for nothing”.

“it doe-sn't m-m-matter any-more”.

The muzzle flash lit up the dark foundry for a fraction of a second. The bullet tore straight through the center of Woods' forehead. His eyes rolled back instantly, his knees buckling as his body crashed hard against the cold, wet concrete, dead before he even hit the ground.

The silent echo of the gunshot died away, leaving only the sound of the rain.

Fendra collapsed. Her knees gave out, her body slamming hard onto the freezing, wet floor beside the corpse. She lay there in the dirt, gasping, her mind short-circuiting from the raw trauma of the recoil, the blood, and the finality of the choice.

But the woman who slowly rose back up from the wet concrete wasn't the one who had just pulled the trigger.

The trembling stopped. The slouch vanished. As she wiped the rain and the stray splatters of crimson from her cheek, her eyes hardened back into black flints.

It was Synthia.

Synthia didn't feel joy. She felt the cold satisfaction of a completed ledger. Slowly, she pocketed the gun, knelt beside the corpse, and unclasped the heavy, unpolished steel bracelet from his left wrist. The metal was still warm from his skin. She rose back to her feet, holding the heavy link up to the pale, greasy light filtering through the cracked skylight.

She knew this bracelet. She had stared at the old, grainy photographs of their mother for hours, memorizing the heavy, industrial steel band that never left her wrist. The bracelet her mother had kept until the day she died, the one with her husband's name engraved deep on the inside. When the father received the call about his wife's death, that original bracelet vanished lost to time, buried in some evidence locker or stolen by the slums.

But Synthia had seen the exact same distinct, heavy steel links on Detective Woods' wrist. She thought he had found it. She thought it was the proof. She thought Woods was the son of the abuser from twenty-three years ago her and Fendra's half-brother.

Her fingers traced the scratched surface, searching for the unique engraving of Fendra's father's name. Her thumb caught a groove. She turned the bracelet over, squinting through the dim, grey shadows.

The name wasn't there.

Instead, etched cleanly into the inside of the steel link, were the words: *PORT ERYBUS CADET — BATCH '21*.

Synthia's breathing stopped. The clinical stillness in her chest shattered.

She stared at the metal. It was a standard-issue academy graduate bracelet. Mass-produced. Cheap. A piece of scrap iron given to every single rookie who passed through the Port Erybus precinct. It looked identical to the one her mother used to wear but it was completely different. A cruel, visual coincidence.

The puzzle pieces in Synthia's mind violently re-ordered themselves, and the calculation fell apart into pure horror.

The entire premise of her vengeance was a lie. Woods wasn't her half-brother. He wasn't connected to the abuser, and he wasn't carrying the bloodline of the man who ruined their mother.

He didn't wear the bracelet because he was connected to her family's past. He wore it because he was a rookie cop trying to project authority in a lawless town, wearing the exact same standard-issue junk every other cadet wore.

He had investigated Cassandra's death purely out of a desperate, unrequited love for a woman who could never love him back. He had tracked down the clues because he was a good detective who smelled fresh lacquer and saw four nails in a floorboard.

There was no bloodline of a monster to extinguish. The idea that Woods was her half-brother was nothing but a ghost she had been chasing in the dark. Synthia had dragged Fendra back to Port Erybus for a lie. She had brutally murdered Cici, and now she had executed an innocent man, all to balance an equation that was flawed from the very first line.

The heavy steel bracelet slipped from her fingers, clattering uselessly against the wet concrete, rolling into the dark puddle of blood beside Woods' lifeless hand.

